Redesigning an Internal Workflow Tool for Executive Assistants

An enterprise UX research project focused on improving workflow efficiency, usability, and safer tool adoption.

At McKinsey & Company, I worked as a Senior User Researcher supporting internal tools used across the firm. One of my primary projects focused on improving the experience of Executive Assistants, a critical user group responsible for coordinating complex workflows, managing sensitive information, and supporting teams across a fast-paced consulting environment.

The existing tool experience was difficult to navigate and did not fully support the way Executive Assistants actually worked. As a result, users had developed their own workarounds, including Excel-based processes, to complete tasks more efficiently. While these workarounds helped users get their work done, they also created inconsistencies, duplicated effort, and potential security risks around sensitive information.

Our goal was to better understand the Executive Assistant community, identify the biggest workflow and usability pain points, and design a more intuitive future-state tool experience.

Project Snapshot

Project / Client: Internal workflow tool for McKinsey’s Executive Assistant community
Timeline: July 2022 – March 2023
Role: Senior User Researcher
Team / Stakeholders: User Research Lead, Software Architect, Product Manager, senior managers, Executive Assistant users, internal product stakeholders
Problem Space: Improving an internal workflow experience that did not fully support how Executive Assistants worked, leading to inconsistent workarounds and potential security-related risks
Methods: Stakeholder workshops, survey research, user interviews, heuristic evaluation, usability testing, concept testing, personas, journey mapping, prototyping
Tools: Figma, Qualtrics, Miro, Dovetail, Excel, Jira, Microsoft Office
Outputs: Personas, journey map, research synthesis, interim Excel solution, low-fidelity prototype, high-fidelity prototype, user stories, acceptance criteria
Outcome / Impact: Created a tested interim solution and a development-ready future-state prototype to improve workflow clarity, tool adoption, and safer handling of sensitive information
Focus Areas: Enterprise UX, internal tools, workflow design, usability testing, product strategy, research-to-design

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The Challenge

Executive Assistants play an essential role in keeping internal operations running smoothly. Their work often involves coordinating across people, systems, calendars, documents, and sensitive information.

However, the existing internal tool did not fully align with their day-to-day workflows. Users found parts of the experience difficult to navigate, inefficient, or disconnected from how they actually completed their work.

Because the tool was not meeting their needs, many Executive Assistants had created their own informal systems and Excel-based workarounds. This was understandable from a user perspective — they were trying to get their jobs done — but it created a larger business problem.

The challenge became:

> **How might we design a more intuitive and secure workflow experience that better supports Executive Assistants and reduces reliance on inconsistent workarounds?**

My Role

As Senior User Researcher, I supported the project from discovery through future-state design.

My role included helping understand the Executive Assistant experience, identifying pain points in the current workflow, synthesizing research into actionable insights, supporting concept testing, conducting usability testing, and translating findings into design recommendations.

I also contributed to the creation of personas, journey maps, an interim Excel-based solution, and a high-fidelity Figma prototype that was prepared for development.

Because this was an internal enterprise product, the work required balancing user needs with operational realities, technical constraints, stakeholder priorities, and security considerations.

Research Approach

We used a mixed-methods research approach to understand the current-state experience and identify opportunities for improvement.

Our research included:

Stakeholder workshops to understand business goals, internal constraints, and known pain points
Survey research to gather broader feedback from the Executive Assistant community
User interviews and usability testing to understand workflows, frustrations, and unmet needs
Concept testing to evaluate early solution directions
Personas and journey mapping to align the team around user needs and workflow stages
Heuristic evaluation to identify usability issues in the existing experience
Prototype testing to validate design decisions before development

The goal was not just to document frustrations. It was to understand why users were relying on workarounds, what their ideal workflow needed to support, and where a redesigned tool could reduce friction.

Key Research Findings

1. The existing tool did not match the way users actually worked.

Executive Assistants had developed their own ways of managing information, tracking tasks, and coordinating workflows. The official tool experience did not always support those behaviors clearly or efficiently.

This created a gap between the designed workflow and the real workflow.

2. Workarounds were a symptom of unmet needs.

The Excel-based workarounds were not the problem by themselves. They were evidence that users needed more flexibility, clarity, and control than the existing tool provided.

Rather than treating workarounds as user error, we treated them as research data. They helped reveal what users valued: speed, visibility, organization, and practical control over their process.

3. Usability issues created operational risk.

When users moved sensitive information into informal tools, the experience became harder to standardize and secure. Improving usability was therefore not just about making the tool easier to use — it was also a way to encourage safer adoption of approved systems.

4. Executive Assistants needed a tool that supported both structure and flexibility.

The workflow required consistency, but it also needed to account for variation across users, teams, and working styles. A rigid tool would not solve the problem if it failed to reflect how complex and context-dependent the work actually was.

5. Stakeholder alignment was critical.

Because the product touched multiple teams and internal processes, research needed to create shared understanding across product, architecture, leadership, and end users. Personas, journey maps, and usability findings helped make user needs more visible to decision-makers.

Personas and Journey Mapping

To help the team align around the Executive Assistant experience, we developed personas and a journey map that captured key user needs, behaviors, pain points, and workflow stages.

These artifacts helped translate research into a shared language for the cross-functional team. They also made it easier to identify where the current experience broke down and where a redesigned tool could provide the most value.

The journey map was especially useful for showing how pain points accumulated across the workflow, rather than appearing as isolated usability issues.

Image placement: Add persona and journey map visuals here.
Suggested caption: *Personas and journey mapping helped align stakeholders around the Executive Assistant workflow and identify key moments of friction.*

Low-Fidelity Prototype

After synthesizing the research, we moved into low-fidelity prototyping to explore potential improvements to the workflow.

The low-fidelity prototype allowed us to test early ideas before investing too heavily in visual design or development. We used this stage to evaluate whether the proposed structure made sense to users, whether the navigation felt intuitive, and whether the workflow better matched how Executive Assistants expected to complete their tasks.

Feedback from usability testing helped us identify what needed to be clarified, simplified, or reorganized before moving into higher fidelity.

Image placement: Add low-fidelity prototype screens here.
Suggested caption: *Low-fidelity prototypes helped us test workflow structure and navigation before moving into detailed design.*

Interim Solution

Because the future-state tool required development resources, we also worked on an interim solution that could support users sooner.

This interim solution used an Excel template to create more consistency and structure in the workflow while the longer-term product experience was still being developed. We tested the interim solution with users and used feedback to refine it before broader use.

This was an important part of the project because it acknowledged a real business constraint: users still needed support before the redesigned tool could be built.

The interim solution helped bridge the gap between current-state pain points and the future-state product vision.

Image placement: Add interim solution screenshot or anonymized workflow visual here.
Suggested caption: *The interim solution gave users a more structured workflow while the future-state tool was being prepared for development.*

High-Fidelity Prototype

Using findings from research, concept testing, and usability testing, we created a high-fidelity Figma prototype for the future-state tool experience.

The prototype incorporated user feedback from earlier testing and was designed to be clear, practical, and ready for stakeholder review.

The high-fidelity prototype included:

Improved navigation
Clearer workflow structure
More intuitive task completion paths
Design updates based on usability feedback
User stories for Jira

Acceptance criteria to support development handoff
A stakeholder-ready presentation format

Although the product was still waiting on development resources during my time on the project, the prototype gave the team a validated direction and a clearer path toward implementation.

Image placement: Add high-fidelity Figma screens here.
Suggested caption: *The high-fidelity prototype translated research findings into a development-ready future-state workflow.*

Research-to-Design Impact

This project helped shift the conversation from “users are not using the tool correctly” to “the tool is not fully supporting the way users need to work.”

That distinction mattered.

By grounding the work in research, we were able to show that adoption challenges were tied to real usability and workflow issues. The research helped the team understand why users had created workarounds, what risks those workarounds introduced, and how a redesigned experience could better support both user needs and business goals.

The final outputs helped the team move forward with:

A clearer understanding of Executive Assistant workflows
Research-backed personas and journey maps
A tested interim workflow solution
A future-state prototype ready for development planning
User stories and acceptance criteria for Jira
Stronger stakeholder alignment around the product direction

Why This Project Mattered

This project reinforced that internal tools deserve the same level of research and design rigor as customer-facing products.

When internal tools are hard to use, people do not simply stop working. They create workarounds. Those workarounds can be creative and effective, but they can also introduce inconsistency, inefficiency, and risk.

By improving the user experience, we were also supporting better operational behavior: clearer workflows, safer tool usage, and less reliance on fragmented processes.

For me, this project was a meaningful example of UX research driving both user advocacy and business value.

Reflection

This project taught me a lot about enterprise UX, internal tool adoption, and the relationship between usability and organizational behavior.

One of my biggest takeaways was that resistance to a tool is often rational. If users are avoiding a system, there is usually a reason. The researcher's job is to understand that reason deeply enough to help the team design something better.

I also learned how valuable it is to create practical solutions at different time horizons. The high-fidelity prototype represented the future vision, but the interim Excel solution addressed a more immediate need. Both were important.

Looking back, this project strengthened my ability to work across research, product, design, and technical teams. It also helped me see how UX research can influence more than an interface — it can shape workflow strategy, adoption, and the way an organization supports its employees.

What I'd Do Differently Today

If I were approaching this project now, I would spend even more time defining success metrics early in the process.

For example, I would want to track:

Reduction in workaround usage
Task completion time
Error rates or duplicate work
User confidence
Adoption of the approved workflow
Support tickets or help requests
Perceived ease of use before and after the redesign

I would also want to continue testing the high-fidelity prototype with a broader range of Executive Assistants before development, especially across different tenure levels, working styles, and team structures.

Even with those limitations, this project gave me valuable experience turning ambiguous internal workflow challenges into research-backed product direction.

Short Version for the Project Card

Redesigning an Internal Workflow Tool for Executive Assistants
Conducted UX research and prototyping for an internal McKinsey workflow tool supporting the Executive Assistant community. Research revealed usability gaps, workaround behaviors, and security-related risks, leading to an interim Excel solution and a development-ready Figma prototype with user stories and acceptance criteria.

Tags

Enterprise UX · Internal Tools · UX Research · Workflow Design · Executive Assistant Experience · Usability Testing · Concept Testing · Personas · Journey Mapping · Figma · Jira · Research-to-Design · Product Strategy